

FLY CASTING MASTERY WORKSHOP

2-Day Course · Module One — The Foundational Stroke · Student Handout

STRATEGY

Knowledge · Wisdom · Intent

LINE CONTROL

Pause · Power · Path

TACTICS

Active · Passive · Erratic

Name: _____

Date: _____

THE TWO RULES OF FLY CASTING

Rule 1: What the rod tip does, the line does.

Rule 2: Don't forget Rule 1.

1 Why We Need a Foundational Stroke

20 min

CUE *Poor practice doesn't just stall you — it wires the wrong movement into your muscle memory.*

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- Two Rules of Fly Casting: Rule 1 — what the rod tip does, the line does. Rule 2 — don't forget Rule 1
- Casting originated ~1850: Samuel Phillippe's 6-strip cane rod, braided silk lines, and fixed guides made shooting line possible
- Direct feedback from a coach is irreplaceable — books and video lack real-time correction that wires correct movement into muscle memory
- Poor practice sessions don't just stall progress — they actively encode faults via myelin (Daniel Coyle, The Talent Code)
- The Fly Fisher's Triad: Strategy + Line Control (Pause/Power/Path) + Tactics — the organizing map of the whole course
- The vertical casting plane is derived from tournament casters — four decades of proof that it works for everyone

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- None — concept introduction only
- Q&A: surface and correct misconceptions before any rod touches a hand
- Two Rules quiz: instructor calls a fault, student names which Rule was broken

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ I can state both Rules without looking
- ☐ I understand why structured practice matters more than time on the water

2 Pause, Power & Path — The Three Components

25 min

CUE *Back off and think smooth. Most students use too much power, too early.*

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- Pause / Power / Path: the three components of every cast, every mend, every on-stream presentation — the Fly Fisher's Triad of line control
- A.L.E. (Jason Borger): A = Acceleration (smooth start, tip travels as straight as possible) → L = Loop Formation (the flick out of the line plane) → E = Energy Transfer (dead-still stop)
- Pause: timing — the period after the backcast that allows the line to straighten. Creep is a fault; Drift corrects it
- Power: rate of movement — negative, constant, and positive acceleration all produce different rod loads and loop outcomes
- Path: what the rod tip does, the line does (Rule 1). Straight tip path = tight loop. Concave path = tailing loop
- One fault in any component cascades immediately into the other two — they are inseparable

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Tug-of-war feel drill: student holds leader end, instructor holds fly line — student feels tension before touching a rod
- A.L.E. pantomime (Mel Krieger, 1975): perform the casting motion without a rod — develop muscle memory before adding rod and line
- Fault cascade drill: instructor changes only the pause — students observe how power and path are immediately affected

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ I can describe all three phases of A.L.E.
- ☐ I know what Creep is and how Drift fixes it
- ☐ I can identify which component broke when my cast goes wrong

3 The Three-Point Grip & Casting Methods

20 min

CUE Grip is the final link in the kinetic chain — it starts at your feet, not your hand.

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- Three casting methods: Wrist Only → Forearm → Whole Arm (most advanced — widest range of control)
- Whole Arm Casting evolved from tournament casting. Walter Mansfield cast 133 feet in 1899 — world record for 35 years
- Three-Point Grip: index finger up on the handle. Used by George Selwyn Marriott ('Prince of Fly Fishers') — hit a 1-inch target at 20 yards
- Three-Point allows the wrist to fully participate AND enables more precise rod pointing
- Thumb-on-Top: power and distance. V-Grip: finesse and soft delivery
- Grip pressure: the handshake principle — firm enough to control, loose enough to feel the rod flex

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Grip pantomime: form Three-Point Grip without a rod, eyes closed, 5 repetitions — build proprioception
- Pencil-tip drill: tape a pencil to the rod tip — observe how 1 cm of wrist deviation moves the tip dramatically
- Method comparison: cast 5 times wrist-only, 5 forearm, 5 whole arm — student observes and describes loop difference

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ I can form the Three-Point Grip without looking at my hand
- ☐ I understand why Whole Arm is the foundation for everything advanced

4 Whole Arm Casting — The Overhead Cast

30 min

CUE Arm lift and wrist flick end at the same time — NEVER arm first, then wrist.

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- The 'C' Pickup: flip the rod tip in a C to tension the line before casting — never cast a slack line
- Backcast: forearm parallel to ground, rod accelerates back and up. Hand rises to face-height, outside the shoulder
- Mac's Pipe: in the L phase, the rod tip is flicked out of the line plane. Swift movement — abrupt stop
- The casting arc is variable — there is no single fixed stop point. For a first backcast carrying 30–50 ft of line, stop close to vertical so the backcast climbs above horizontal on the pickup. That's all that's needed, because the next stroke is the delivery
- Drift during the pause: rod drifts back and up a few inches — extends the forward stroke
- Forward cast: karate-chop motion. Arc length and stop point adjust with how much line is out and the loop size you want — more line or a wider loop opens the arc; less line or a tighter loop closes it
- False casting repeatedly is a poor choice when fishing — work toward delivering the fly on the pickup or the very next stroke
- The Casting Chart: hang at elbow height (base line = forearm length). Move hand along stroke line — most reliable tool for training straight tip path

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Casting Chart: hang at elbow height, student moves hand along stroke line 20 repetitions before picking up a rod
- Mac's Pipe drill: develop the flick — abrupt stop must be sharp and crisp before adding to the full cast
- Stop-and-hold backcast: cast backward with 30–50 ft of line, hold the rod near vertical for 3 seconds — instructor verifies the backcast climbs above horizontal
- Mirror drill: cast facing a full-length mirror — identify which body segments move on each cast

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ My backcast consistently climbs above horizontal, whatever arc length gets me there
- ☐ Arm lift and wrist flick end simultaneously
- ☐ I am using the whole arm — shoulder, elbow, forearm, wrist

5 The Casting Triangle & Loop Analysis

15 min

CUE Every loop shape is a direct readout of what the rod tip did. Rule 1 is always at work.

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- Rod Leg: from rod tip to the nose of the loop. Fly Leg: from fly to the nose. Both must be in the same plane
- Loop size = how far the rod tip is flicked out of the line plane (the L phase). ONLY the flick controls loop size
- Tailing Loop: caused by a concave rod tip path (pushing instead of karate-chopping). Causes wind knots and lost distance
- Wide Power Loop: butt-flexed cast — fast, high-energy, used for distance
- V-Loop: rod tip describes a V (Thrust Cast) — cuts into wind
- Tight triangle = efficient energy. Wide/collapsed triangle = wasted energy

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Slow-motion film with tip path tracing: draw the path on screen, student names the loop type and its cause
- Prediction drill: instructor describes a tip path in words — student draws the resulting loop before casting
- Five-clip diagnosis: five unlabeled clips — student ranks tightest to widest and explains the tip path behind each

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ I can name the rod leg and fly leg in my loop
- ☐ I know what caused a tailing loop (and which Rule it violates)
- ☐ I can produce a tight and a wide loop intentionally

6 The Backcast — Trajectory & the 180 Rule

25 min

CUE The backcast must climb above horizontal — like an airplane on takeoff, not leveling off on the runway.

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- The 180 Rule: backcast must be exactly opposite the target — when honored, every segment of line moves as one unit (synergy)
- Trajectory: the backcast climbs above horizontal — the airplane-on-takeoff angle means the line is perfectly positioned when the pause ends
- Drift (not Creep): drift the rod back and up a few inches during the pause — extends stroke length without losing the stop point
- Pause length scales with line length — more line in the air requires more pause time
- Sidearm Casting: tip the rod to the side — keeps line lower, less visible to fish, less wind exposure, under obstacles
- Shooting on the backcast is possible sidearm — turn and point the rod down the line, use the 'O' Ring for line control

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Stop-and-look drill: cast, stop, turn — watch the line fully lay out and diagnose trajectory
- Wall drill: 3 feet from a wall — physical, immediate consequence for a level or downward backcast
- Partner call drill: partner calls 'now' when line fully unrolls — internalizes pause timing from outside the caster
- Obstacle simulation: set physical obstacles to simulate bank vegetation — student adapts backcast angle and plane

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ My backcast consistently climbs above horizontal
- ☐ I understand the 180 Rule and why violating it costs me distance and accuracy
- ☐ I can adjust my backcast angle for a tight space

7 The Forward Cast — Integration & Synergy

25 min

CUE *Feel the rod load before starting forward. Don't chase the line — wait for it.*

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- The forward cast is the payoff of everything before it — faults here trace directly back via Rule 1
- Timing: begin the forward cast before the line falls — feel the rod load during the A phase
- Karate-chop forward stroke: smooth acceleration to the flick (L) and a dead-still stop (E). The stop transfers all energy
- The 'O' Ring: line hand forms an O-ring around the line while shooting — full line control at all times. Essential for fishing
- Lift and Point after shooting: lift rod and point it down the rod leg — reduces guide friction and adds distance
- Synergy (Aristotle): the integrated cast takes many practice sessions to feel connected. Explicitly normalize this.

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Target drill: hula hoop at 30 ft — 5 of 6 before advancing
- Distance ladder: 20 → 25 → 30 → 35 ft — only advance when loop stays tight and 'O' Ring is used
- 10-cast self-evaluation: score each cast Pause/Power/Path (1-3), identify the dominant pattern, write in journal
- Integration flow: 15 minutes of uninterrupted casting — instructor observes only, no corrections

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ I am using the O Ring on every shoot
- ☐ I can feel the line load before starting the forward cast
- ☐ I can self-score my cast on Pause, Power, and Path separately

8 The Elliptical Stroke, Sidearm & Cross-Body Casting

1h 7m

CUE *The Elliptical Stroke eliminates the collision problem — the fly travels away from you, not through your cast.*

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- The Elliptical Stroke (Hans Gebetsroither, Traun River, Austria, mid-1930s): also called the Belgium Cast or Constant Tension Cast
- Backcast is made sidearm; forward stroke is made more upright — rod describes an ellipse during the pause
- Applications: split shot, weighted flies, multiple fly rigs, sink tip lines, huge flies — any time overhead cast is insufficient
- Sidearm Casting: any angle tipped to the casting arm side — keeps line lower, less visible, under obstacles
- Cross-Body Casting: sidearm across the front of the torso — for short ranges when casting arm side is blocked
- Across the Head Casting: rod across the top of the head — much stronger stroke, used with Elliptical and hauling
- The Switch: Roll Cast backswing done quickly — line sweeps back, D-Loop forms, forward stroke begins before D-Loop falls

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Elliptical Stroke pantomime: slow-motion arm motion in the ellipse — verify the path describes an ellipse, not a straight line
- Weighted rig cast: use Elliptical Stroke to cast a split shot rig — compare turnover vs. overhead
- Sidearm accuracy: cast sidearm to a target at 30 ft — maintain accuracy while reducing rod plane
- Switch pantomime: slow-motion — verify D-Loop forms before the forward stroke

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ I can execute the Elliptical Stroke for a weighted fly rig
- ☐ I know when to use sidearm, cross-body, and across-the-head
- ☐ I understand what problem the Switch solves

9 Casting in the Wind — All Four Directions

1h 7m

CUE *The Double Haul is the centerpiece of all wind casting. Less time in the air = less time for wind to ruin the cast.*

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- Wind from Line Hand Side (easiest): haul + Kentucky Windage (aim off-target to compensate) + keep line as low as possible
- Wind from Casting Arm Side: line can blow across the angler dangerously. Across the Head Casting is the real solution
- Wind from Behind: Elliptical Stroke — cast low on backstroke (haul hard), come up and around high on forward stroke
- Wind into the Face (hardest): greatest air resistance. Squat Cast + haul + cast the line ON the surface of the water
- The Thrust Cast: flick and thrust the rod tip toward target simultaneously during L — casting arm straightens down the rod leg. Creates a V-Loop
- The Thrust on backcast: done slightly sidearm — point the rod back down the line. Combined with a haul, achieves remarkable backcast distance

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Four-direction wind carousel using a fan: student applies correct strategy for each direction, naming the technique before executing
- Thrust Cast pantomime: build very slowly — flick and thrust must be absolutely simultaneous before adding speed
- V-Loop verification: film the Thrust Cast from the side — verify the rod tip describes a V shape
- Wind simulation shoot: cast into a fan headwind using Squat Cast — measure distance vs. normal overhead

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ I know the correct response for all four wind directions without hesitation
- ☐ I can produce a V-Loop with the Thrust Cast
- ☐ I understand why casting low reduces wind interference

10 The Double Haul, Triple Haul & Distance Casting

1h 7m

CUE *'Haul Late.' Say it out loud on every single repetition until it is automatic.*

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- The Double Haul (Marvin Hedge, 1934): pull sharply on the line with the line hand during the L phase — increases line speed to ~3x without extra arm effort. Immediately broke Walter Mansfield's 35-year world record
- Haul timing: the haul MUST come during L (Loop Formation). The mantra 'Haul Late' prevents hauling too early
- Learning sequence: Single Haul on backcast first → line hand immediately returns → Single Haul on forward cast → combine
- The return is the most commonly neglected step — after the haul, the line hand must immediately return upward before the next stroke
- Triple Haul: a third haul after E. Immediately = turns over a reluctant leader. Delayed 1-2 sec = creates S-Curves for drag-free drift
- Triple Shoot: Slip + shoot on backcast + shoot on forward cast — the ultimate distance technique

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Haul-only drill: line-hand haul motion without casting — feel the motion in isolation
- Clap drill: instructor claps at the L moment — student hauls at the clap, internalizing timing from an external cue
- Single Haul backcast: add haul to backcast only — measure loop speed visually and by feel
- Double Haul distance comparison: 5 casts without haul, 5 with — record the distance difference
- Triple Haul: practice the delayed third haul — observe S-curve formation and leader turnover effect

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ I can execute a Single Haul on both backcast and forward cast with correct timing
- ☐ My line hand returns immediately after every haul
- ☐ I understand the Triple Haul as a line management tool, not just a distance tool

11 Mending — In-the-Air, On-Water & Curves

1h 7m

CUE 'Cast/Reach' — say it out loud. The reach happens while the line is still in the air, not after it lands.

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- Mending: changing the position of the line after the cast — on the water or in the air before the line lands
- In-the-Air Mending is always preferred: it introduces controlled slack that can readily be manipulated. On-water mending disturbs the fly
- Reach Mend: cast to target; while line is flowing, reach the rod tip to the side. Line drops on the hypotenuse of a triangle. Say 'Cast/Reach' out loud
- Curve Mend: reach to the side and then reach back — places a curve in the line at any point from rod tip to fly
- Puddle Mend: aim the forward cast above horizontal, then drop the rod tip after E — creates a puddle of controlled slack
- Parachute Mend: cast horizontally, then pull rod back to vertical after E — line parachutes down to the surface
- Mend and Shoot: shoot line as the rod is reached — extends the cast without additional false casts
- Five curve types: Aimed, Torque Twist (Hook), Overpowered, Underpowered, Mended — each places the curve differently

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Mend carousel: instructor calls a mend type, student executes — Reach, Curve, Puddle, Parachute, Mend-and-Shoot
- Drag indicator drill: foam indicator on leader — student adjusts mend until indicator drifts freely. Visual proof of drag elimination
- Curve type round: student produces each of the five curve types on command, naming the mechanism used
- Three-scenario carousel: riffle, eddy, undercut bank — student selects the correct cast and mend for each

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ I can execute all four mend types on command
- ☐ I understand the difference between in-air and on-water mending
- ☐ I know which curve type places the curve at the fly vs. at mid-line

12 Presentation Accuracy, Roll Cast & the Switch

1h 7m

CUE Roll Cast setup: do the backswing SLOWLY. So slow the line never leaves the surface — it just slides.

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- Accuracy: trajectory control + consistent stop point + timing = repeatable fly placement. Track hit percentages
- Roll Cast: forward cast without a backcast. The D-Loop (from rod tip T to surface point P) stores the energy; the Anchor provides resistance
- Roll Cast backswing: done SLOWLY so the line never leaves the surface — it slides toward the angler. Wrist tips back to 30 degrees
- The flick at the end of the Roll Cast forward stroke is critical — the energy in the D-Loop lifts and casts the Anchor
- Sidearm Roll Cast: keep the rod fully sidearm throughout — immediately after the stop, point the rod directly at the target
- The Switch: when the Anchor is too long for the D-Loop to lift. Backswing made quickly — D-Loop flows behind before forward stroke
- Sidearm Switch: Switch made fully sidearm — allows longer casts and is effective against wind

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- 12-inch ring accuracy at 30 ft: 6 attempts, track and record hit percentage
- Roll Cast setup-only drill: practice forming a clean D-Loop and correct Anchor point — no forward stroke until setup is correct
- Roll Cast to 20-ft target: 4 of 6 clean deliveries before adding distance
- Obstacle simulation: cast from a position where a physical obstacle prevents a backcast — student chooses Roll or Switch

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ I can describe D-Loop and Anchor and their roles
- ☐ I can execute a functional Roll Cast that delivers the fly without a backcast
- ☐ I know when to use the Switch vs. the Roll Cast

CUE You now have the vocabulary. Practice builds the fluency.

WHAT WE COVER IN THIS STEP

- Before/After video reveal: compare the baseline film from Step 1 with today's casting — student narrates differences using Pause/Power/Path and A.L.E. language
- The Fly Fisher's Triad in review: Strategy + Line Control + Tactics — where does each student sit on each side of the triangle?
- Structured practice beats unstructured repetition: 80% focused repetition of known skills, 20% exploration of new skills
- Personal fault library: each student's top 3 recurring faults, described in their own words, with specific corrections — the self-coaching tool that carries forward
- Measurable benchmarks: accuracy percentage, distance in feet, loop consistency score — track progress with data, not feelings
- Practice design: the role of rest and mental rehearsal — casting is stored in myelin, built by correct repetition, consolidated by rest

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Before/after video side-by-side: student narrates differences using course language
- 8-week written practice plan: created in session, reviewed and signed off by instructor
- Personal fault library: student writes top 3 faults and specific corrections — instructor countersigns
- Partner accountability: exchange contacts, schedule one video-review call within two weeks of the course

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ I can see clear improvement in my before/after footage
- ☐ I have a written 8-week practice plan with specific weekly goals
- ☐ I have a personal fault library I can use to self-coach between sessions

My Personal Fault Library

Use this page after the session. Identify your top recurring faults and write the correction in your own words.

Fault #1

What it looks / feels like

Which component broke: Pause / Power / Path · A.L.E. phase: A / L / E (circle one)

My specific correction

Fault #2

What it looks / feels like

Which component broke: Pause / Power / Path · A.L.E. phase: A / L / E (circle one)

My specific correction

Fault #3

What it looks / feels like

Which component broke: Pause / Power / Path · A.L.E. phase: A / L / E (circle one)

My specific correction

Quick Reference Card	
The Two Rules	Rule 1: What the rod tip does, the line does. · Rule 2: Don't forget Rule 1.
A.L.E.	A: Acceleration — smooth start, straight path · L: Loop Formation — the flick out of the plane · E: Energy Transfer — dead-still stop
Pause / Power / Path	Pause: let the line unroll before the forward cast · Power: smooth, then accelerate · Path: straight tip path = tight loop
Common faults	Tailing loop: concave tip path — karate-chop, don't push · Wind knot: almost always a tailing loop (Rule 1) · Crash landing: trajectory too low
The Fly Fisher's Triad	Strategy (knowledge, wisdom, intent) + Line Control (pause, power, path) + Tactics (active, passive, erratic)
Practice tip	80% focused repetition of skills you know. 20% exploration of new ones. Short, correct sessions beat long, sloppy ones.